

micadistilleryjennifer

Ireland is a great place to sample whisky. I caught up with one of the Emerald Isle's best distilleries, Travel Radio Australia, and we're continuing our series on Ireland, and Ireland wouldn't be the same without Irish whisky. We have Jessica Cornelia here from the Mickle Distillery in Salt Hill, Galway, Ireland, and Jessica, welcome to the programme.

Thank you very much. Thanks for having me. Now Jessica, tell us about the Mickle Distillery.

It's a very special place. Sinead from Tourism Ireland was telling me that you have lots of very interesting guests and a few superstars dropping in. It's a very special place in Ireland.

Yeah, it's great. So we are Mickle Distillery, as you said, in Salt Hill, a small village just on the outskirts of the city, and we are sixth generation distillers. So Mickle is actually the gentleman that owns the distillery right now.

It's their great, great, great grandfather's name. So Mickle is a very old Irish name. It's a name that really isn't around anymore today, so we wanted to honour that and keep it alive, so that's why we called it Mickle.

So when I say that they are sixth generation distillers, we're actually the first in the family to be legally distilling. It pretty much means that we pay our taxes now, but maybe they weren't so much in the past. So the family started by distilling Pochine.

And to explain what Pochine is, Pochine is the native spirit of Ireland. It's one of the oldest spirits in the world. And the first written record of it actually is in 1324 in the Red Book of Ossory.

So the monks were making it, and basically they were calling it Aquavite. So Aquavite is the Latin for water of life, because I guess it's clear, they believed you drank it, gave you life, it was quite medicinal, maybe sometimes a bit too much life. So what happened was people around Europe began to take this and adapt it and change it to suit their own languages and their own cultures.

So because in Ireland we were speaking Irish, we were actually calling it *Ishka Baha*. So *Ishka* means water, *Baha* means life, so same thing, water of life. I suppose over time then *Ishka Baha* shortened into *Fwishka*, which you'll actually see in a lot of Irish whiskey bottles.

And *Fwishka* is the original term for whiskey in the Irish language. So historically Pochine and whiskey actually used to be the exact same thing. The only thing that made them different was whether you paid your taxes or not.

Because in 1661 there was taxes introduced, and basically if you paid your taxes they called you a whiskey maker. If you didn't pay your taxes they referred to you as a Pochine maker. It didn't really deter us, we were still making it, if we weren't making it we were drinking it.

So they made it completely illegal in the 1700s, this is making Pochine. So then basically much later on in the 1800s they began to age whiskey and they began to separate. So today they are two completely separate spirit categories, they have their own technical files and their own rules.

Pochine remained completely illegal in Ireland until 1997, so it's not that long that we're actually allowed to make it. So when we set up the legal distillery in 2016 we were just making Pochine. We wanted to show people not only how important it is for Irish culture and for Irish history, we wanted to show how versatile it is.

So we started with just making the Pochine, we've since expanded into making an amazing Irish gin, the Irish whiskey and we have an Irish cream liqueur as well. So the family is still very much heavily involved, our head distiller is one of the six generations and we offer tasting experiences. So people can come in and they can visit the distillery, it's about an hour long, they learn all about a much longer version of what I've just told you.

All about the history of the family, Pochine, whiskey, what the differences are and how it all works and they get to see our production area as well. So it's a really small distillery, we're one of the smallest in Ireland but it's very unique, it's very authentic and people just love to come and visit us. Now you're in Galway, Salt Hill Galway and tell us about this particular part of Ireland, it's very beautiful.

It's stunning, we're right by the sea, just on the edge of the city and the family originated from Connemara so I suppose a lot of our focus on the spirits is to not forget where we came from but it's great to be in the city because Galway is an amazing place to visit. It's a city of music, of culture, of festivals and it's great to have also indoor attractions that people can come and visit and when people come to Ireland they absolutely love to drink and learn about Irish whiskey and now we're educating people on Pochine as well. You're here in Connemara on the French Riviera, the Cote d'Azur with your tasting and what are you offering people here? So today I have three of our products with us, we have a much larger range but I just decided to focus on three today so I have our classic Pochine.

So that is 100% malted barley with a little botanical called a bog bean. Then I also have our Inverin whiskey, it's a blended whiskey so blend is when you're mixing different styles of whiskey together. So it's aged in an ex bourbon cask, finished in an ex Pedro Jimenez sherry cask and it's a little bit petered so just 25% of the grains are petered.

And when I say it's petered it means that basically the grains have been kind of smoked with turf or peat and we're very fortunate that we have our own bog out in Connemara so we cut our own turf and we send it to our malters. So we're one of the very few places in Ireland that actually have the ability to do that so that's great. And then I also have our Irish gin, it's a contemporary gin so what that means is it focuses on the botanical so there's 17 botanicals in there.

Four of which we actually pick in Connemara as well in Galway and it's a magnificent gin, it won the best Irish contemporary gin at the World Gin Awards about two months ago. And tell us about the casks you have, are they local casks the way you aged the whiskey in there? So with the casks they aren't local, a lot of Irish and Scottish whiskey all start in a bourbon cask and I suppose one of the main reasons for this is in the States and when they're making bourbon they're only allowed to use it once and they can't have used it before for anything. So once it's been used, once they're done with it, whereas in Ireland we have no restrictions on how many times we can use a cask.

So we usually start off the whiskey in a bourbon cask, so Irish typically spend about four years in a bourbon cask and then we finish it in something else. So the one I have with me today has been finished in a Pedro Jimenez sherry cask, we have others then that are finished in a Madeira dessert wine cask from Portugal, a Bordeaux red wine cask from France, so we finish it in something different. So in Ireland we're a little bit more not restricted in what we can use, so for instance I'll just explain that in America they're only allowed to use oak for their casks, in Scotland they're only allowed to use oak but it can be any type of oak, so it can be European, Japanese, American oak.

In Ireland we're allowed to use any type of wood that we like as long as it doesn't leak we don't actually care, so we're a little bit more relaxed about the whole thing. So we end up using a lot of oak because of the ex-bourbon casks but we would also use some chestnut and some different types of wood. Sinead from Tours in Ireland was telling me that you have some quite well-known people visiting you, tell us a bit about that.

Yes we've been very lucky, about two years ago we had Gordon Ramsay visit us for his travel show on National Geographic, so we actually took him to the bog and we take him right back to the start and show him how to cut turf or peat, so we had him out there doing that. That was brilliant, it gave us an amazing boost, we have people still visiting us two years later saying that they saw the show and we also managed to correct him. So Gordon Ramsay is Scottish and we managed to correct him, he thought that Scotland invented whisky but Ireland actually invented whisky 50 years before Scotland, so they can't claim that.

But anyway then most recently just last week it aired we had Eugene Levy from the Reluctant Traveller and Apple TV come visit us and again we took him out to the bog to make Irish bog water coffees and we had him take out some turf as well. And again that's been such a great boost, a great profile obviously Apple TV and National Geographic. But even we've had a lot of people over the years from Belgian TV, French documentaries come profile us and show the distillery and we get a lot of visitors from that and it's been absolutely fantastic.

We actually get people to sit down around a table, we only take about between 20 and 25 people, it's an hour long experience and you're just specifically with one guide and they're teaching you everything about it. It's very authentic and unique and personable and people absolutely love it

because they often get to see the head distiller who's one of the family, there's not a lot of distilleries you can go to that you can actually see a working distillery like that and get to talk to the head distiller, ask him questions. He loves to interact with the guests, we love interacting with the guests.

We also like love giving recommendations for other things to do in Galway and so it's not just all about our whisky, it's about making the best experience for the guests that's possible. I'm speaking with Jessica Cornelia, the head of the Visitor Operations and Direct Sales at Mickel Distillery in Salt Hill Galway in Ireland. How can people find out more about you and the Mickel Distillery online? Yeah, so we have a website, mickeldistillery.com and if you hop on there you'll be able to see the shop and you'll be able to see how to book a tour and we also give a bit of history about the family as well.

We have a really great Instagram page, TikTok page, so we are online as well so if anybody wants to look us up. Obviously on YouTube as well we have the clips from Apple TV and the Reluctant Traveller and also the National Geographic. And we will say it's Mickel, that's M-I-C-I-L, not K-I-S-O, M-I-C-I-L.

Do you speak Gaelic yourself? Just Koopla Fockel, but actually the first language in the distillery is Irish. The Porek and Jimin who have the distillery are from South Cunnemara and a few of the other staff are from Cunnemara, so the first language is actually Irish. So I would have it from school, I would have the basics, but I am not a fluent Irish speaker, but they are teaching me Koopla Fockel, maybe not all the best words, but yes.

And maybe you can say something in Gaelic to our Australian listeners across Australia, maybe say K-Mila Fockel I think is a thousand welcomes to your distillery. Yeah, K-Mila Fockel. That's all we need, K-Mila Fockel and of course the most important one is Sláinte.

Sláinte wá, so you'll hear a lot of people in Ireland saying Sláinte, so yes that means cheers, but the full and the correct way to actually say it is to say Sláinte wá, which the exact translation means to good health. Oh that's, you've cleared that up, that's fantastic, so because everyone's been saying Sláinte, so you're now going to say Sláinte wá. Sláinte wá.

And then you'll appear like you're true Irish. Exactly, yeah. Well thank you so much to you Sméregate, which means God bless you in Gaelic as well, and thank you very much for being on Travel Radio Australia.

Thank you very much Jeffrey, it's been an absolute pleasure.